

Theme - Workbook 1

Identify themes and connect them to character choices, change, and evidence.

How to use this workbook

Each passage is literary. Choose the theme that is developed through more than one event or detail. A theme must be a complete idea, not just a topic word.

Before you start

- Track change. Compare what the character believes or does at the beginning and end.
- Find the turning point. A choice, consequence, or realization often reveals what idea the story develops.
- Demand evidence. Before choosing a theme, identify at least two details that support it.

Text 1 - The Extra Chair

For the first week of the workshop, Hana sat beside the same two friends at lunch and rarely spoke to anyone else. On Friday, she noticed a new student carrying a tray past several full tables. Hana almost looked away, then moved her backpack from the empty chair beside her. The new student sat down and asked about the afternoon session. By the end of lunch, Hana's two friends were comparing notes with him. The next Monday, Hana left the extra chair open before anyone arrived.

1. Which statement best expresses a theme of the passage?

A. Small acts of inclusion can make unfamiliar situations easier for more than one person. B. People should always sit with different classmates at lunch. C. Workshops are a good place to make friends. D. Hana eats lunch with two friends before meeting a new student.

2. Which detail most strongly supports the theme in answer A?

A. Hana had two friends in the workshop. B. The new student carried a tray. C. Hana left the extra chair open before anyone arrived the next Monday. D. The afternoon session happened after lunch.

Text 2 - The Cracked Bowl

Owen carried a clay bowl home from his first pottery class and set it on the kitchen shelf. The next morning he found a thin crack along one side. He considered throwing it away before his sister asked whether he could repair it. At the next class, the instructor showed him how to strengthen the crack with a visible line of dark glaze. Owen had hoped the repair would disappear, but when the bowl came out of the kiln, the dark line made the shape more interesting. He placed it back on the shelf where the crack could be seen.

3. Which statement best expresses a theme of the passage?

A. Imperfections can become part of what gives something value or character. B. Dark glaze is stronger than other types of glaze. C. Broken objects should never be thrown away. D. Owen makes a bowl that cracks after pottery class.

4. Which change in Owen most clearly develops the theme?

A. He takes a pottery class. B. He moves from wanting the repair hidden to accepting the visible line. C. His sister asks about the bowl. D. He puts the bowl on a kitchen shelf.

Text 3 - The Last Rehearsal

Maya had been chosen to introduce the school concert, but she practiced the opening line so many times that it began to sound unnatural. During the final rehearsal, she forgot a sentence and froze. The music teacher told her to explain the concert to the empty seats as if she were speaking to one person. Maya tried again without looking at her script. She changed a few words, paused where she needed to, and finished. On concert night she kept the script in her pocket but never unfolded it.

5. Which statement best expresses a theme of the passage?

- A. Confidence can grow when people focus on communicating rather than performing perfectly.
- B. Scripts should not be used at school concerts.
- C. Music teachers know how to solve every speaking problem.
- D. Maya forgets part of her introduction during rehearsal.

6. Which detail best supports the theme?

- A. The concert is held at school.
- B. Maya keeps the script in her pocket but does not unfold it.
- C. The teacher speaks to Maya during rehearsal.
- D. Maya changes a few words.

Text 4 - The Garden Map

Eli wanted the community garden map to be exact, so he spent an afternoon measuring every path. When two volunteers pointed out that several older gardeners used informal shortcuts between beds, Eli said those paths were not part of the plan. The next week he watched one gardener carrying watering cans take a shortcut because the official path added several minutes. Eli returned to his map, added the commonly used routes with dotted lines, and labeled them "walking paths observed on site."

7. Which statement best expresses a theme of the passage?

- A. Good plans may need to change when real experience reveals something the original design missed. B. Maps should include every possible route a person could take. C. Community gardens are difficult to measure accurately. D. Eli spends an afternoon measuring paths in a garden.

8. Which detail most clearly shows Eli's change?

- A. He measures every official path. B. Volunteers tell him about shortcuts. C. He adds the observed routes to the map with dotted lines. D. A gardener carries watering cans.

Answer key and reasoning

1. A. A is developed through Hana's choice, the group interaction, and her changed behavior on Monday. D is plot summary; B is too absolute; C is only a topic-level observation.
2. C. C shows that Hana's one-time choice became a lasting change in how she approached inclusion.
3. A. A is supported by Owen's shift from wanting to hide the crack to displaying the repaired bowl. C is too absolute; D is summary.
4. B. The change in how Owen views the crack directly develops the theme about imperfection and value.
5. A. A matches Maya's shift from memorizing perfectly to speaking naturally. D is only the plot event that triggers the change.
6. B. B shows the result of Maya's increased confidence and new approach.
7. A. A is developed through Eli's initial insistence, his observation, and his revision of the map.
8. C. C shows that Eli acts on what he learned rather than simply hearing the criticism.

Mistake check

- Picked a one-word topic? Turn it into a complete statement about what the story suggests.
- Picked the plot? Ask what the events show, not merely what happened.
- Picked a "life lesson" that sounds nice? Make sure at least two concrete details from the passage support it.